

1. Participants

The participants for this study are a corpus of nine primary texts, including six articles that were published facing the artists that utilize these platforms, and three explainers that were published by Instagram, TikTok, and YouTube.

2. Method and Instrument

The method that will be used for this investigation is qualitative discourse analysis, which utilizes a two-pass coding instrument to examine and categorize the texts according to their meanings.

3. Ethics

The method that will be utilized for this research study is ethical due to the fact that it uses only publicly available texts from the platforms.

4. Alignment

The method that will be used for this research study relates to the research question in particular in that it examines the perceptions of artists regarding the impact of algorithms on their artistic identities.

5. Limitations

The main limitations to the use of this method are the small size of the sample of texts that will be analyzed, as well as the fact that it is not possible to access the code or analytics reports of the platforms.

6. Justification

The discourse analysis method will be used for this research study due to the use of Braun and Clarke's (2006) thematic framework to analyze the texts, which ensures the trustworthiness and replicability of the research study.

Methodology

The qualitative discourse analysis was appropriate for answering the research question about how artists discuss algorithms on social media platforms. Therefore, discourse analysis was utilized for this project to determine how artists within various communities discuss the concept of algorithms and their impact upon visual art and artists.

The texts were collected through targeted searches on the web between April 28 and May 1, 2026 using terms like "Instagram algorithm artists," "Instagram dead for artists," "independent

artists social media algorithm,” “artists algorithm reach collapse,” “algorithm anxiety artists,” and “Instagram for artists do's and don'ts.” Each of these texts needed to focus upon visual artists, discuss social media algorithms, be accessible to the public, and discuss their artistic work with those criteria. In addition to these texts by artists, three official texts from social media platforms (Instagram, TikTok, and YouTube) were also collected and utilized to provide a comparison between the two concepts. More specific comments, discussions outside of the platforms’ official channels, and paywalled content was excluded from this research for both ethical and practical reasons.

The results of this research included six texts written by and for artists, and three texts from the social media platforms explaining their algorithms. The texts written by the artists included discussions from Hyperlux Magazine, GinAngieLa.com on social media’s “Social Art Dilemma,” two blog posts from Saturno discussing Instagram and moving away from the social media platform, a post from Sara Leger discussing whether Instagram is worth using as artists, and a blog post from Gallery 4% that provides advice to artists considering Instagram as a social media platform for their art. The explanations from the social media platforms included Instagram’s description of the ranking of posts on the social media platform, an explanation from TikTok of its “For You” page recommendation system, and YouTube’s help page that explains the platform’s recommendation system for videos on the platform. These two groups of texts were selected in order to provide a more comprehensive discussion on the topic while still remaining focused upon the research question.

Table 1

Corpus Used for Discourse Analysis

Source	Type	Use in analysis
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Kahn (2025)	Artist-facing article	Reach collapse, content demands, burnout, alternatives
GinAngieLa.com (2024)	Artist essay	Account status, recommendation limits, paid boosts
Saturno (2024a)	Artist blog post	Paid visibility, product posts, independent artist survival
Saturno (2024b)	Artist blog post	Website/newsletter as response to Instagram dependence
Leger (n.d.)	Artist studio blog	Authenticity, local networks, rejection of spectacle
Ganguly (2025)	Artist advice article	Process content, Stories, algorithm anxiety
Mosseri (2023)	Platform explainer	Instagram ranking across Feed, Stories, Explore, Reels
TikTok (2020)	Platform explainer	For You feed signals and personalization
YouTube Help (n.d.)	Platform explainer	Recommendation signals and user feedback

The unit of analysis was meaning units, which were defined as the sentences or short paragraphs within the texts that made a specific claim regarding the topics of analysis. Each of the texts was read by the researcher, and each of the meaning units related to the research question were highlighted. During the first pass in coding the texts, codes were created that described the concept of each highlighted meaning unit. These codes included terms like reach collapse, audience instability, format pressure, paid visibility, emotional strain, authenticity, platform explanation, and exit strategy. During the second pass in comparing the codes created during the first pass, the codes were grouped into three main categories. This two-pass method of coding and categorizing the texts is recommended by Braun and Clarke (2006) in their recommendation that qualitative themes should be developed by moving from coded patterns to interpretive themes. The process of developing these themes was utilized to increase the trustworthiness of the research by explaining the formation of each theme, ensuring that each theme was present in multiple texts, and examining for disconfirming evidence, even within the advice texts for

Instagram artists. Furthermore, such an approach to theme development was recommended by Nowell et al. (2017).

This methodology has some limitations in relation to the research question. The research does not attempt to represent all Instagram artists, nor does it attempt to measure the reach of Instagram accounts. The texts were public texts with persuasive elements, as they were written either to provide advice to Instagram artists, to criticize Instagram itself, or to explain the ranking of Instagram posts. Thus, these findings only apply to the analysis of discourse among Instagram artists, and do not make any claims regarding representative artists. Despite these limitations, the discourse among these groups of artists is still a means of gaining valuable insights into the way in which those artists are making sense of the platform and its algorithms.

The research was ethical in that all texts utilized were publicly available texts written for broad audiences. No private texts, usernames of Instagram artists from the comment sections of their Instagram posts, or other personally identifiable nonconsented data were collected. Furthermore, the research utilized the original texts from the authors in most cases, except for in instances in which brief quotations from the authors were essential to the interpretation of certain concepts by those authors. However, the intention of this research is not to reveal the individual texts or artists, but only the general pattern of discourse among the artist communities.